Dean Rusk's initial reaction on the morning of 16 October was: 'I think also that Berlin is very much involved in this. For the first time, I'm beginning really to wonder whether maybe Mr Khrushchev is entirely rational about Berlin.'[89] Moreover, as Naftali and Zelikow observe, the secret recordings of Kennedy's meetings 'make abundantly clear that [Kennedy's] preoccupation was not with Cuba or the immediate threat to the United States. He feared that, if he did not insist on the removal of the missiles, Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev would be emboldened to try to take over West Berlin.'[90] As noted, Kennedy would then have to choose between abandoning two and a half million West Berliners or using nuclear weapons.

So how far was Berlin a factor in Khrushchev's thinking? Ambassador Roberts in Moscow believed the link between Berlin and Cuba certainly existed:

> because in Khrushchev's calculations there must be some connexion between Berlin and every act of policy. The question of questions, he is inclined to say, is disarmament; but the more immediate problem is Berlin; a solution of which would significantly contribute to disarmament.
>
> From this starting point and recalling Khrushchev's well-known proclivity for setting out on courses of action without correctly forecasting where they could lead him, coupled with his undoubted talent for making the best of the resulting situation, I cannot help feeling that the purpose of installing the missiles in Cuba was general rather than precise i.e. to strengthen the Soviet power position in the world *a toutes fins utiles* [for all practical purposes]. In [this] context disarmament (more especially in the sense of dismantling bases) and Berlin would naturally loom large.[91]

In November 1962 Sir Frank reflected: